Assembling Play/*Unfolding Space*

Kerstin Kjellin Larsson

Degree of Master of Fine Arts in Design – Spatial Design
Konstfack – University of Arts, Crafts and Design

Supervisor degree project: Teres Selberg
Examiner degree project: Kristina Fridh
Supervisor report: Helen Runting
Examiner report: Kristina Fridh
Spring 2025



KONSTFACK
University of Arts, Crafts and Design

Abstract

Assembling Play/Unfolding Space explores opportunities for play in areas affected by war and crises. Using small means and simple methods, the work investigates how play and spatial change can be supported in locations with limited access to safe play environments, with the aim of temporarily transforming spaces not adapted for children into more inviting places. The project acts as a tool that enables children effected by displacement to play, construct and shape spatiality in their local surroundings.

The connection between play, participation, and placemaking is explored in the study, highlighting how these approaches can be applied in the design of environments for children. It draws on existing research into the role of art and play in psychosocial care, examining how creative activities can support resilience and foster a sense of place.

By applying the concept to the Swedish non-profit organization Better Shelter's existing emergency response system, the project aims to reach a wide range of children and their families and thereby spread the potential for play and placemaking in temporary settlements and refugee camps.

Key words: play, displaced children, spatial design, play environments, emergency response system, placemaking, participatory design, temporary settlements, refugee camps

Acknowledgements

Thank you to Teres Selberg, my main tutor throughout this project, for your encouragement, consistent support, and inspiration.

Eva Porcuna Ferrer from Better Shelter, Kalle Ekroth from Pin Pin Studio, and Sara Granath from Save the Children thanks for your time and valuable input.

Finally, thanks to the staff and volunteers who took part in the workshops—especially Mahmoud Diab from Save the Children—and above all, to the children who participated.

Table of Contents

Chapter I/ *Introduction*

1.1 Introduction..... 1

1.2 Purpose and Research Questions 3

Chapter II/ *The Question of Why*

2.1 Background..... 4

2.2 The United Nations Convention on the Rights of the Child..... 6

2.3 Refugee Camps and Temporary Settlements..... 7

2.4 Better Shelter..... 8

Chapter III/ *Designing for Children*

3.1 Play..... 12

3.2 Participation..... 13

3.3 Place..... 14

Chapter IV/ *Design Process*

4.1 The Manuals..... 15

4.2 *Form and Function*..... 17

4.3 Flora and Fauna 18

4.4 The Toolbox..... 20

4.5 Workshop..... 21

4.6 Reflections from the Workshop..... 23

Chapter V/ *Design Proposal*

5.1 Concept & Idea..... 25

5.2 Material..... 25

5.3 The Product..... 27

5.4 The Manual..... 28

5.5 Spatialty..... 29

5.6 Placement..... 30

Chapter VI/ *Discussion and Conclusions*

6.1 Summary and Discussion 34

6.2 Final Reflections 36

List of/ *References*..... 40

Chapter I/
introduction

40 % of all displaced people are children

(UNHCR, *Figures at a Glance*, 2024)

Assembling Play/Unfolding Space explores opportunities for play in areas affected by war and crises. Using small means and simple methods, the work investigates how play and spatial change can be supported in locations with limited access to safe play environments, with the aim of temporarily transforming spaces not adapted for children into more inviting places. The project acts as a tool that enables children affected by displacement to play, construct, and shape spatiality in their local surroundings.

Based on Article 31 of the Convention on the Rights of the Child, as I describe in more detail in Chapter II, this project explores the possibility of supporting and empowering children through participatory and exploratory methods.

Play has become recognised as a need that must be met and safeguarded as a crucial part of children's educational and psychological development. Several reports have shown that opportunities for play in the built environment may help children deal with the trauma of displacement and help them adapt to a new place (Weir, Khan & Marmot 2023). Further, I have studied the the role of art in psychosocial care and looked at how participatory design and play value could be used when designing for displaced children. The project aims to explore ways to increase access to play and creative activities in contexts where educational resources and playgrounds are limited. Displaced children, in particular internally displaced children are among those who suffer most. My aim is to work for the child's best interests, to promote displaced children's right to growth and recovery.

By applying the concept to the Swedish non-profit organization Better Shelter's existing emergency response system, the project aims to reach a wide range of children and families and thereby spread the potential for play and placemaking in temporary settlements. With playful

motifs inspired by flora and fauna, children shape their own space by putting together and create spatial worlds. The project is a tool and method for children to engage with spatiality through play.

Assembling Play/Unfolding Space seeks to investigate the intersection of spatial agency, creative autonomy, and the right to play within the broader context of displacement and instability, integrating these insights into my master's thesis in Spatial Design at Konstfack University of Arts, Craft and Design.

The report guides the reader through the research and design process, beginning with an introduction to the project's purpose and research questions. It then provides background and context to the project, including frameworks like the United Nations Convention on the Rights of the Child. Key concepts such as play, participation, and place are explored before detailing the design process, focusing on form, function, and theme. I then presents the design proposal, discussing concept, materials, and the final product, and concludes with a summary, discussion, and reflections on the project's implications and future directions.

1.2 Purpose and Research Questions

The project focus has been to design to support play, playfulness and social context for children affected by war or crisis. The aim has been to work for the child's best interests, to promote displaced children's right to growth and recovery. My intention has been to explore a method for children to engage with spatiality through play, with the aim to promote a sense of ownership towards the space and at the same time making their near environment more playful and child oriented.

- How can play be catered for in situations of crisis?

- How can temporary spatial interventions be designed to support safe and child-friendly environments for the best interests of children affected by displacement?

- And further, how can opportunities for play and creative activities be integrated into existing emergency response systems?

Chapter II/
the question of why

In the following chapter, I introduce the background and context of the project, explain its significance, and outline the situation faced by displaced children. I discuss why it is important to study the conditions of displaced children in these contexts and present research and information on refugee camps and the emergency response system, Better Shelter, which provides temporary homes for families. Furthermore, I review the principles of the United Nations Convention on the Rights of the Child and reflect on how they can be applied when designing for children.

2.1 Background

It is challenging to comprehend the reality we inhabit, to witness war from a distance, and to confront the accompanying sense of hopelessness. This project originated in October 2024, in response to the escalating war against the Palestinian people and the continuous ongoing illegal occupation of Palestinian land, which should be seen within a broader historical context of over a century of colonization, occupation, and dispossession (Khalidi 2024). The systematic violence and widespread destruction in Gaza served as a catalyst for the development of this work, with the notion that Gaza is one of the most densely populated places on Earth—home to more than 2 million people, nearly half of whom are children (Russell 2023).

Forensic Architecture, a research agency based at Goldsmiths, University of London, working across human rights, journalism, architecture, academia, and law has been collecting data related to attacks on civilians and civilian infrastructure by the Israeli military. Their analysis and research *An interactive cartographic platform: 'A Cartography of Genocide'* reveals the near-total destruction of civilian life in Gaza. As of early 2025, over 90% of Gaza's population has been displaced, approximately 62% of housing units have been damaged or destroyed, and the region's plant life and agricultural infrastructure have suffered extensive destruction (Forensic Architecture 2025).

Children are particularly vulnerable in times of war, as their environment and sense of security are often destroyed. Despite having specific rights under the UN Convention on the Rights of the Child, these are frequently among the first to be violated in conflict situations.

In Gaza, children face a combination of physical, psychological, and social challenges that make their situation uniquely severe within the context of war. The situation is dire with an extreme concentration of violence, displacement, and blockade. Many children are now living in temporary shelters without access to basic necessities. The ongoing insecurity and loss of safety have led to widespread psychological issues among children, including post-traumatic stress, anxiety, and depression. (War Child 2024) Many children express a strong desire to return to school and engage in play, underscoring the urgent need for reconstruction efforts and the restoration of hope.

Children are deprived not only of their homes, but also their social environments, schools, and places of play amidst the destruction wrought by war. The home, often regarded as the most fundamental setting in a person's life, serves not only as protection against the elements but also as a source of psychological security. In contexts of armed conflict or crisis, the challenge lies in establishing a new space and sense of existence in the world — however temporary or inadequat that arrangement may be.

2.2 The United Nations Convention on the Rights of the

Every child has the right to rest and leisure, to engage in play and recreational activities appropriate to the age of the child.

(UNCRC A*rticle 31*)

The foundation of *Assemblening Play/Unfoldning Space* lies in the United Nations Convention on the Rights of the Child, with particular emphasis on Article 31, which underscores the significance of play and recreational activities in children's lives.

The UN Convention on the Rights of the Child is an international agreement on childhood, a statement on how to protect children's rights, with 54 articles that cover all aspects of a child's life: their civil, political, economic, social and cultural rights. The 54 articles are deeply interconnected, reflecting a holistic and indivisible approach to the realization of children's rights. Central to this framework are four guiding principles: non-discrimination (Article 2), the best interests of the child (Article 3), the right to life, survival, and development (Article 6), and the child's right to be heard (Article 12). These principles inform the interpretation of all other rights, including Article 31 (UN 1989).

As previously noted, although the convention outlines specific protections, these rights are often among the first to be violated in situations of armed conflict. This highlights the urgent need to implement a variety of interventions for children, including opportunities for play and learning.

2.3 Refugee Camps/ Temporary Settlements

Camps are designed to be temporary settlements that provides basic goods and services needed to survive. Families have often been forced to flee their homes due to conflict, persecution, or disaster, experiences often characterised by loss of familiar environments, social structures and the need to adapt to uncertain living conditions—sometimes over prolonged periods.

Children living in refugee camps face a multitude of challenges that affect their physical, psychological, and social development. Displacement can create a pervasive sense of instability and uncertainty, where children in refugee camps face a lack of agency—with limited opportunities to express their views or influence their surroundings. This lack of control can compound feelings of helplessness and marginalization. As education researcher Paul O'Keefe writes in the article *Art as a Passport for Learning and Healing in Refugee Camps*, "Millions of children are caught up in refugee camps that are designed to contain them rather than help them flourish" (O'Keeffe, 2023). Access to education and opportunities for play—both critical components of healthy child development—is often severely restricted. While some camps may host makeshift schools or learning centers, these are frequently under-resourced and inconsistent in quality. Similarly, safe and accessible spaces for recreation are rare, despite the well-documented importance of play in helping children process trauma and build resilience (O'Keeffe 2023). Laws and legislations also makes it difficult to build permanent interventions for play within refugee camps.

Nonetheless, even in these adverse conditions, moments of resilience, creativity, and joy persist. When provided with safe environments, children often engage in meaningful ways—through art, informal education, or play—that foster connection and healing. Programs that prioritize child-friendly spaces and participatory approaches not only support well-being but also help lay the foundation for a more hopeful and empowered future, helping children regain a sense of normalcy and empowerment (UNICEF 2021).

2.4 Better Shelter

During the course of my project, I engaged with various organizations working in contexts where crises have occurred or are ongoing. My aim was twofold: to gain a deeper understanding of these complex situations and to explore the possibility of collaborating with local organizations. This would allow the project to be grounded in local realities and ensure that the needs and desires of children and relevant stakeholders were central to its development. I aimed to explore whether, and in what ways, my expertise as a designer and spatial practitioner could contribute meaningfully. Being aware of my position, I did not want to impose my own ideas in contexts where they might not be needed.

However, reaching local organisations and stakeholders within the project's limited time frame proved more difficult than I had anticipated. I contacted several organisations working with displaced children through various creative practices, including design and architectural studios engaged in participatory interventions for displaced children, but with limited success.

Despite not securing a local collaboration, I decided to continue developing my idea to further explore the potential directions of the project. Subsequently, I engaged with organizations connected to Sweden, including Better Shelter, a Swedish non-profit organization that provides temporary housing for displaced populations worldwide. I recognized potential for collaboration and project anchoring with Better Shelter, which has delivered nearly 100,000 shelters across emergency, crisis, and development programs in more than 90 countries (Better Shelter 2025). This meeting proved valuable in several respects, prompting reflection on the variety of emergency response systems currently in operation and the critical roles they play in contexts of war and crisis.

With that in mind, while Better Shelter represents an advancement in emergency housing solutions, its standardized and modular design presents challenges in addressing the diverse needs of displaced populations. A common criticism is that this broad applicability often overlooks

the specific cultural and social contexts of displaced communities, which can potentially lead to discomfort of the shelter (MacGregor 2019). Brett Moore, the UNHCR's Shelter and Settlements Section chief say that local solutions, are often the best, but that they don't always exist (Jacobs 2017). Throughout 2024, Better Shelter piloted a new shelter portfolio in collaboration with humanitarian partners, aiming to collect detailed feedback on potential design improvements, gain insights into local perceptions, and assess the suitability of locally available materials. This process was undertaken to enhance the functionality of the shelters while ensuring cultural relevance and contextual appropriateness (BetterShelter 2025).

I decided to conduct an inventory and close examination of Better Shelter's product to explore whether there were underutilized assets that could be adapted or repurposed to support children's play in vulnerable situations. In our discussions, we considered the needs that arise once the shelters are set up and what materials might be suitable for reuse in creating opportunities for play.

In emergency situations elementary functions must be fulfilled, such as shelter, basic goods and services needed to survive. But at the same time it is important not to forget 'softer', more humane values in contrast to an environment that is rational with great demands on efficiency. I wanted to explore whether these two essential dimensions could be combined in a simple yet effective way.

This led me to explore ways to apply opportunities for play with means that are simple and economical beneficial within an already existing emergency response system to reach as many children and families as possible, with direct and widespread distribution. To include and cater for playfullness within an already existing systems. My proposal aims to ensure that opportunities for play are integrated at the same time as other essential provisions. This will be revisited in Chapter V, p.27, where I present the design proposal, outlining how it can be implemented and providing detailed information regarding the design, materials, and methods.



Figure 1: Better Shelter. (UNHCR)



Figure 2: Ali Haj Suleiman 2023. TT

Chapter III/
designing for children

In this chapter, I present the concepts and methods that have influenced my project, many of which are commonly used when designing for children. I examine how approaches related to play, participation, and place-making are connected and can be applied in the design of spaces for children. More specifically, I explore how these methods can support and positively impact children with experiences of displacement.

I also review existing research on the role of art and play in psychosocial care, and how creative activities can promote resilience and create a sense of place, drawing from both theoretical and practical knowledge. This includes a particular focus on children's participation and influence in design processes, highlighting the importance of play, learning, development, culture, and health. These approaches are often rooted in the principles of social sustainability and aligned with the UN Convention on the Rights of the Child.

My primary focus has been to explore how participatory and play-based methods can meaningfully support children affected by displacement. A particularly valuable resource has been the publications by *CatalyticAction*, an organization that leverages design and architecture to empower vulnerable children, youth, and their communities.

These methods and insights have helped me understand the various considerations necessary when designing for children, which has been of great importance as my project explores ways to increase access to play and creative activities in contexts where educational resources and playgrounds are limited, with the potential for real impact.

3.1 Play

Play is widely recognized as essential to children's educational, emotional, and psychological development. In the context of displacement, opportunities for play can help children process trauma and adapt to new surroundings. It plays a vital role in supporting recovery after crises such as war, as play focuses on the present moment—helping to reduce anxiety and stress (Rigon, Dabaj & Conti 2023).

The term *play* is used broadly and also includes creative activities, which can serve as important tools for communication and participation. It offers children a space for relief, where they can engage in activities that bring joy and comfort. In unfamiliar settings, play and creative activities serve as a universal language that can restore a sense of normalcy and "everyday life" in an otherwise unpredictable world. Shared creative activities can also promote social bonds, reduce isolation, and help children connect across cultural barriers. They help re-establish structure and rhythm, both of which are essential for emotional stability and resilience (O'Keeffe 2023).

As UNICEF highlights in a report, art and play play a crucial role in the psychosocial care and protection of displaced children, significantly aiding their recovery (Nylund, Legrand & Holtsberg 1999). In Gaza, despite the immense challenges posed by ongoing war, educators actively conduct art workshops for displaced children. These workshops not only provide therapeutic outlets for children grappling with displacement and loss but also serve to preserve Palestinian cultural heritage. Such initiatives exemplify the resilience of communities and demonstrate the vital role that art plays in healing and empowerment (Ahmed 2024).

3.2 Participation

The concept of children's participation refers to the active involvement of children in decision-making processes, participation in play is a catalyst for development, agency, and community resilience. Both developmental and rights-based perspectives highlight the multifaceted benefits of involving children in decisions about their play. As UNICEF write in a 2013 report, "When children are encouraged to participate, they learn that their views matter and that they can make a difference in their world". For children in vulnerable or displaced settings, these benefits are amplified, contributing to psychological healing, social integration, and empowerment. When children are involved in planning, shaping, or deciding how and where they play, it promotes their sense of ownership, confidence, and autonomy. They move from passive users to active shapers of their environments. According to *Catalytic Action,* engaging children in the creation of play spaces fosters social inclusion, strengthens community ties, and promotes intergenerational dialogue. Participatory design practices, especially in architecture or spatial design, show how children can help shape the environments they live in, creating more effective and inclusive solutions (Rigon, Dabaj & Conti 2021).

Likned to the concept of child particpation is the term *play value* which refers to how well an object, space, or environment supports meaningful and engaging play for children. The concept is widely used in pedagogy, urban planning, landscape architecture, and child rights work. It emphasizes imaginative, open-ended play and encourages social interaction across age groups, fostering cooperation and communication. Environments with high play value are often adaptable or modifiable, allowing children to reshape or influence the space. This flexibility can reveal creative solutions and support diverse forms of expression. Play value is about creating spaces for versatile and inclusive use, where children can explore and interact in various ways.

3.3 Place

Placemaking is an active process through which individuals or communities, including children, shape and transform their physical environments. It is hands-on engagement that allows children to embed personal and collective meanings into a place, fostering emotional bonds known as *place attachment.*

Several reports acknowledge that limited attention has been given to how children experience the places to which they have been displaced, and how these experiences may influence their health and well-being. At the same time, it is recognized that play and opportunities for play can support children in adapting to new environments following displacement. In particular, the development of place attachment plays a critical role in the formation of self-identity for displaced children who find themselves in unfamiliar surroundings and among new people (Weir, Khan & Marmot 2023).

For those living in temporary shelters or unfamiliar settings, creating or co-creating a space can provide a sense of ownership and control in an otherwise unstable world. Allowing children to shape or define a space gives them a feeling of agency and influence, as they become active participants in building something of their own. Placemaking plays a critical role in supporting well-being and identity, and it encourages collaboration and connection by bringing children together through shared activities (Rigon, Dabaj & Conti 2021).

It is important for children to establish a connection with their immediate living environment in order to develop a sense of belonging (Slingerland, Lukosch & Brazier 2020). Moreover, the processes of envisioning and ultimately constructing such spaces can serve as a form of healing for children whose sense of place attachment has been disrupted by displacement. Place attachment itself is shaped by multiple interrelated factors—including sense of place, belonging, place dependence, place identity, and social connections—which together support a child's capacity for integration into a new environment (Rigon, Dabaj & Conti 2023).

Chapter IV/
design process

In this chapter, I will go through the design process, including spatial references. I will discuss and reflect on the design choices I made in terms of form and theme, and describe the development of the design toolbox and its significance within the overall process. Furthermore, I reflect on a creative workshop conducted with children, exploring its role in shaping the project. These various components and stages of the process have been essential in reaching the final design proposal, and have been connected through an ongoing process of reflection, thematic exploration, and iterative design.

4.1 The Manuals

This project draws inspiration from the architect and thinker Yona Friedman (1923–2019), whom I was introduced to through a collaborative course between Konstfack University and Tensta Konsthall in Stockholm in the fall of 2024. The collaboration was linked to the exhibition *Imagine an After*, which explored the question of what can be contained in an "after." Invinting "artists to an attempt to imagine a space for reflection on different ways forward in a time of escalating conflicts around the world; situations that constantly leave new ruins and the displacement of people in their wake" (Tensta Konsthall 2024). I found Friedman's oeuvre—created outside the conventional realm of architecture—particularly compelling for its straightforward, playful, and user-centered methodologies. One key influence for this project was his folding wall system, which he designed 1945 in response to his own experiences of war and displacement—offering a way to create private and flexible spaces in unstable or temporary living conditions. He created accompanying manuals (Fig. 3), which were not intended as traditional instructions to be followed from A to B, but rather as tools to give users creative freedom. He created the manuals to awaken the user's capacity to think and act independently. They didn't offer direct solutions or fixed guidelines, but instead evoked ideas that were supposted to be easy to put into action (Friedman 2006).

Inspired by Friedmans approach, the project explores whether a similar methodology could serve as a simple method for children to engage with spatiality through play. It considers the potential of such a tool not only to facilitate playful expression but also to enable spatial transformation: making environments more inviting, playful, and responsive to children's needs and perspectives.

Within this framework, the project poses a central question: How can one introduce a method with small means, then let the children take the lead—shaping both the play and the space—through the use of a toolbox.

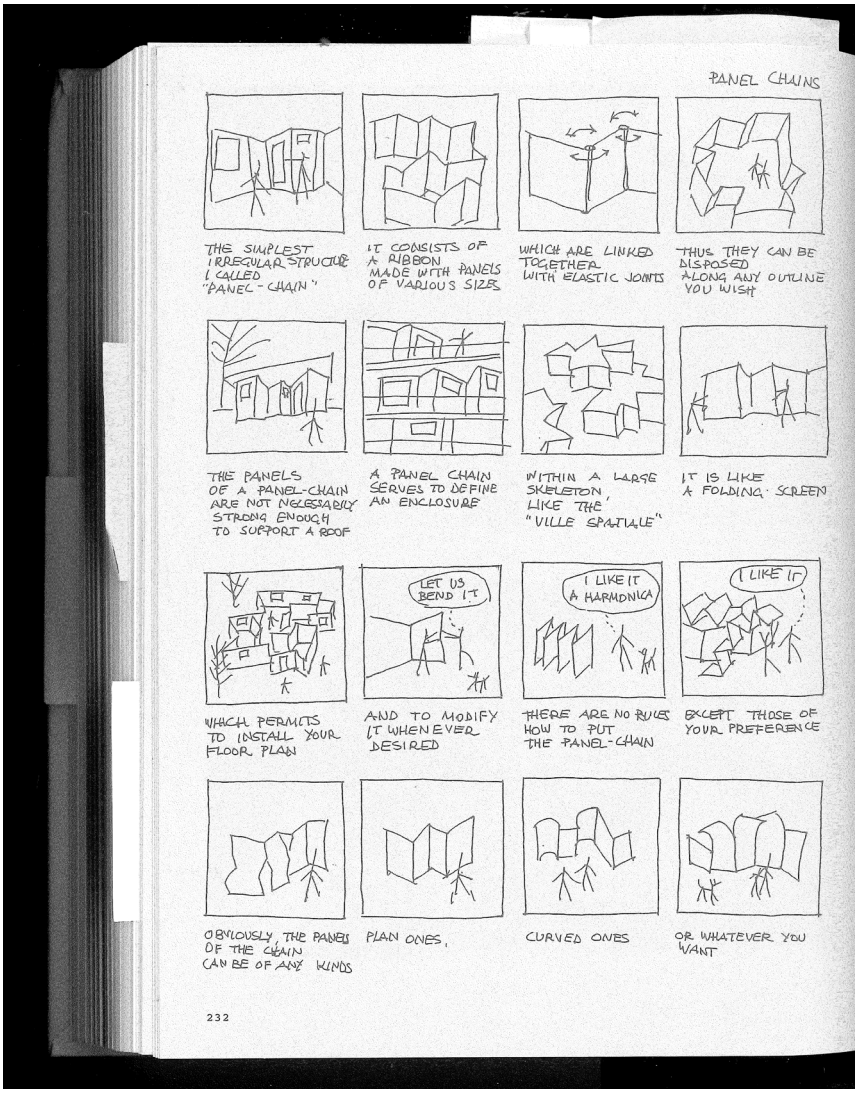


Figure 3: Yona Friedman / Pro Domo 2006 p.232.

4.2 Form and Function

With the gathered research on play and placemaking—and its important role in supporting recovery and resilience—I began developing a series of forms and figures aligned with my concept. My aim was to find a simple way to create spatiality through creative participation and play. The construction needed to be easy to assemble, accessible, and flexible—while also incorporating shapes that felt inspiring and playful to children. I focused on motifs that children could recognize or be familiar with—if not from their immediate surroundings, then from school, books, or film. The elements had to be easy to put together, lightweight, and appropriately sized for children of various ages. The "product" should be able to unfold and be packed away again, easily moved, and be scalable—usable either in small or large configurations, by one child or several.

My aim was for the system to be multifunctional in that it invites play through the act of building, but also transforms into a spatial structure—a wall system that can be used for play but that also can create enclosure, privacy, or shade. I wanted the design to contribute something beyond it's function to support utility; to add a layer of narrative, recognition, and imagination, which I identified as particulary significant for children experiencing displacement and the loss of home and safe play environments. The intention has been to make the forms visually appealing and enjoyable to create and play with—perhaps even as a deliberate contrast to the everyday surroundings—while also offering children the opportunity to add their own ideas and motifs.

Flora and Fauna

Don’t ever be surprised
to see a rose shoulder up
among the ruins of the house:
That is how we survived.

Mosab Abu Toha, *Things You May Find Hidden In My Ear*, 2022

I researched and integrated the theme of flora and fauna into the project due to its symbolic, cultural and emotional significance, as well as its strong associations with resilience and continuity. Nature and vegetation are often rich in symbolic meaning, and across cultures they frequently represent freedom, renewal, and hope. In many narratives such as mythology, literature, and art, nature is where one escapes to for liberation or transformation. Cycles of growth, decay, and regrowth in plants are deeply tied to ideas of starting over, healing, or emotional regeneration.

As part of the project, I studied the wild flora and fauna of Palestine, a region with rich floral biodiversity due to its location at the intersection of three continents (PIBS 2024). In this context, I explored how nature and land are deeply embedded with themes of resistance and resilience, both as a way to preserve and share knowledge and of necessity to sustain life. Nature, in this sense, becomes a symbolic act of resistance, rooted in the historical context of colonization, occupation, and dispossession.

Nature can be a powerful theme in children's play—not just aesthetically, but developmentally and emotionally as well. It is familiar and accessible symbols for many children and connect them to the world around them while supporting imagination and learning in ways that can be both joyful and meaningful. Flora and fauna are universally present across cultures, making them inclusive and widely relatable, children encounter animals, plants, and nature imagery in books, media, and daily life. Even though some of the motifs are abstracted they are recognizable, hopefully making them an intuitive starting point for play that could stimulate imagination and fantasy. A common ground for collaborative play among children from diverse backgrounds that could support social connection.

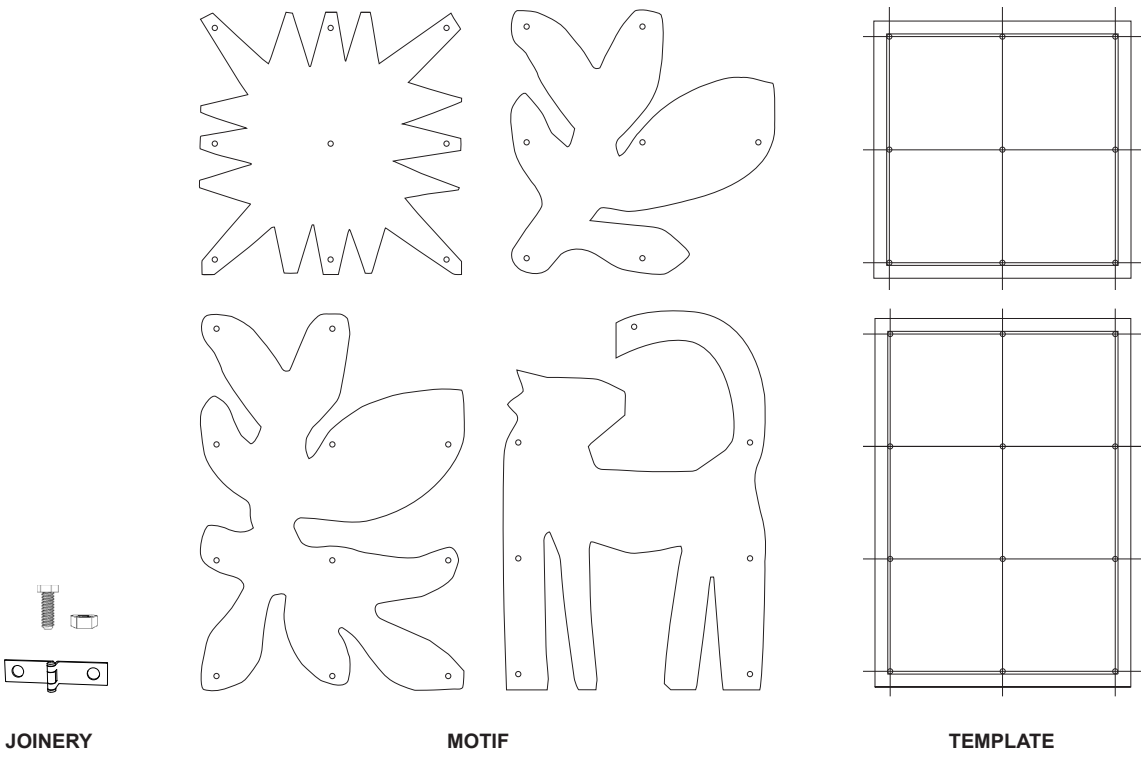


Figure 4: Joinery, motifs and templates (Kjellin Larsson 2024)

4.4 The Toolbox

After creating the visual language I needed to systematize the idea in a way that was simple and easy to understand—both for children and in consideration of the limitations and resources available in different contexts. I discussed local availability of materials and tools with Eva Porcuna Ferrer from Better Shelter to gain a deeper understanding of the conditions in the areas where their shelters are beeing used.

It is important to follow a system and template—not only for the designs I developed, but also to allow children to create their own figures. This would ensure that all forms could be easily connected and assembled together. The aim has been to create a toolbox to be used for play and spatiality, functioning as a deployable and modular system that can be easily assembled, disassembled, and unfolded into temporary spatial configurations. The assembled 'cut-out' motifs are joined with detachable hinges and mountings, clustered together or separated to create new forms and configurations.

I tested several different options for assembling the figures and foldable walls. What is required for assembly are elements such as screws, bolts, and hinges—or materials that can serve similar functions. I experimented with both designed and 3D-printed joinery, as well as with found materials—often considered “waste” or “garbage”—that are affordable, accessible, and widely available in local markets. These include tape, straps, string, metal bands, and discarded materials such as wire casing from electrical cables. This approach opened up many different possibilities for connecting the components in flexible and resourceful ways, which strengthened the project by allowing it to be assembled in multiple ways—either with custom-designed solutions or with locally sourced and discarded materials. My aim is to encourage children to build, create, and define their own spatial environments using the toolbox.

4.5 Workshop

During the design process, I conducted a workshop at Spenshult Asylum Accommodation in collaboration with Save the Children, who run weekly activities for refugee children. The participating children were between 5 and 12 years old, with 3 to 6 children attending each session. A translator working with Save the Children was present, as most of the children did not speak Swedish.

The workshop was planned as a two-day activity. On the first day, we explored different animals, flowers, and plants. The children were encouraged to draw both freely and using the templates I had prepared. The aim was to observe what types of motifs the children would create, and to consider incorporating their drawings into the design.

On the second day, the children continued drawing their own chosen motifs and also began working with cardboard—cutting, drawing, and assembling. We made holes in the cardboard sheets and connected different parts. The cardboard element was particularly appreciated, both as a surface to draw on and as a material to experiment with by creating different formations, such as rectangular and triangular shapes (Fig.5).



Figure 5: Workshop (Kjellin Larsson 2025)

4.6 Reflection from the Workshop

The workshop with the children provided valuable insights into their engagement with drawing and crafting activities. Many of the children appeared familiar with these forms of expression, responding with enthusiasm and finding the experience both engaging and meaningful. However, some children struggled with maintaining concentration. The room where the workshop was held offered a variety of other activities, which may have influenced the children's choice of engagement and attention span.

The assembling activity suited some children well, while others preferred to spend longer periods drawing. Offering a balance between drawing and assembling tasks could have been an effective way to vary the activities and thereby extend the children's engagement and focus during the workshop.

Overall, the children were positive and appeared excited about my presence and the project. Nevertheless, I should have brought more cardboard materials to allow the children to experiment with constructing models at a full scale. I also found it more difficult than expected for the children to generate ideas and motifs independently. A longer collaboration would have been valuable in this regard, as well as having more guiding questions prepared. While bringing images might have helped inspire the children, I was cautious about being too directive in shaping their creative ideas.

Additionally, communicating through an interpreter presented challenges, as the conversations often moved quickly, making it difficult to maintain a natural flow of interaction with the children. Reflecting on the workshop, it became clear that if children are to contribute meaningfully to shaping the motifs of the project, more time would be necessary. I believe that initially engaging with the pre-made figures through play and construction could serve as an effective starting point, inspiring children to develop and invent their own motifs over time.

Chapter V/
design proposal

The next section presents the design proposal, outlining its core concept and underlying ideas. I will discuss the selection of materials and components, explain how the product integrates with Better Shelter's existing system, and demonstrate—through a manual and drawings—how it can be assembled to create spacial change in the areas between and around family shelters.



Figure 6: *Assembling Play/Unfolding Space* (Kjellin Larsson 2025)

5.1 Concept & Idea

The idea was to integrate the concept into an existing emergency response system in order to create more opportunities for play and placemaking. Intended as a tool to assemble play and unfold space, enabling spatial transformation with minimal resources and simple construction. The method temporarily transformes a non-child-friendly environment into a more inviting space for children in locations with limited access to education and safe play environments. By applying the concept within an existing emergency response system such as Better Shelter, the project creates opportunities to quickly and easily reach more children and thereby spreading the potential for play and placemaking. The aim with the concept is for it to be included in all shelter packages at no additional cost to the user, using as little extra material as possible.

5.2 Material

I explored the product and materials of Better Shelter, such as the box made out of cardboard to ship the shelter in, the wall and roof panels and the joinery used to attach the panels to the steel constuction. I decided not to consider the steel pipe from the shelter for this project, both because it can continue to be used after the end life of the panels and also because the material is not familier and easy to work with for children. Instead I focused on exploring ways to use the cardboard, panels and joinery such as plastic screws and bults. I wanted to incorporate play opportunities while minimizing the addition of new materials in to the exsisting emergency response systems, in that way I could minimize cost additions and also use discarded materials. Cardboard is a material that is familiar to many children; it is lightweight, easy to manipulate, and can be painted and modified.

Only minimal additions are required to transform the emballage into a play-oriented toolbox—such as printed templates, along with a small kit containing assembly instructions and joinery components.



Figure 7: *Assembling Play/Unfolding Space* (Kjellin Larsson 2025)

1 shelter = 2 boxes = 24 figures

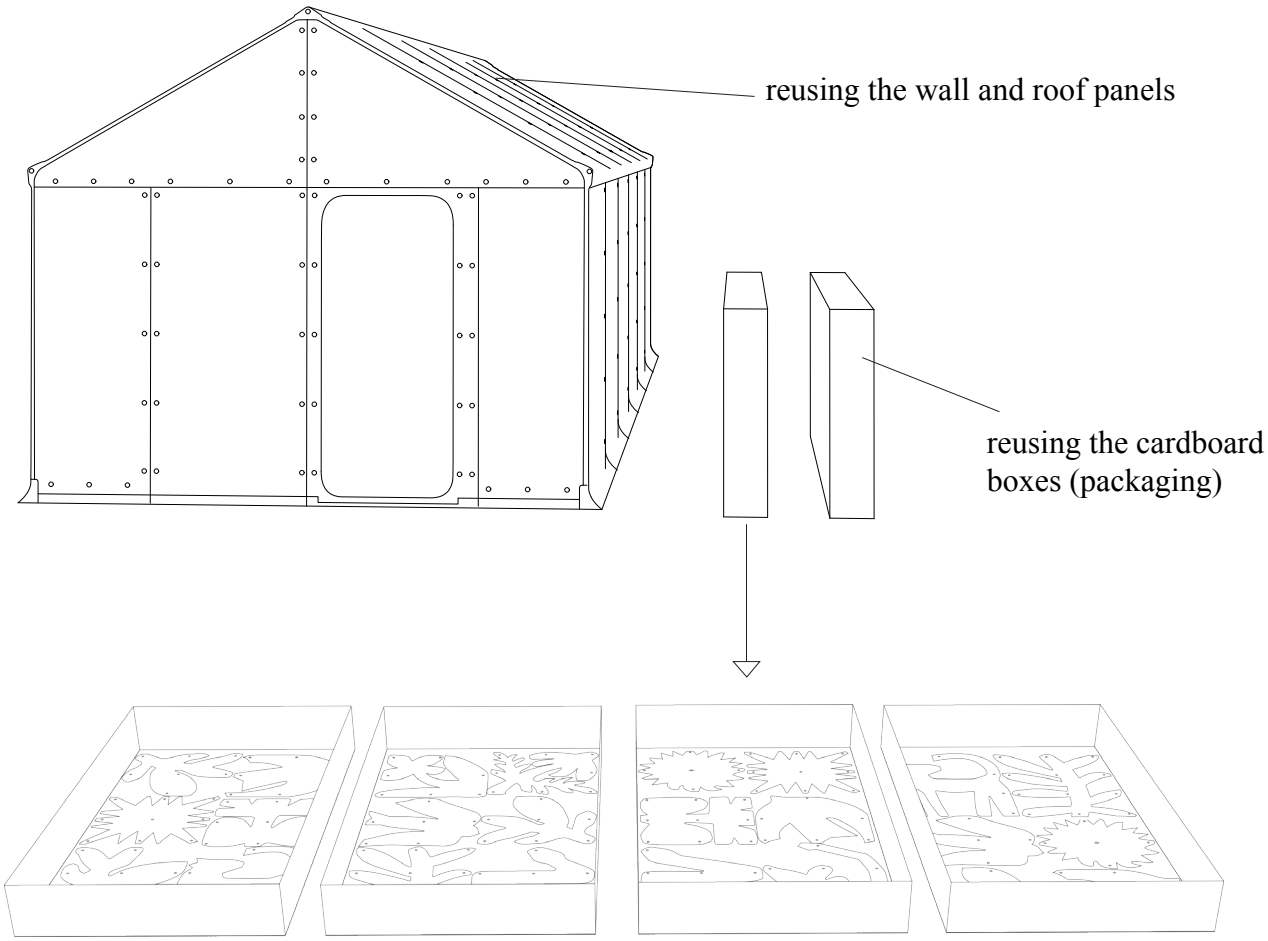


Figure 8: Boxes + Printed Template + A kit with Manual & Joinery (Kjellin Larsson 2025)

5.3 The Product

The printed figures are dimensioned to fit efficiently within the packaging box—two placed side by side, with a total of six figures per sheet, resulting in 24 figures per shelter unit. Each figure has a width of 520 mm and is designed in two height variations—520 × 520 mm and 520 × 745 mm—to create visual and structural variation in the design. The figures include marked points indicating where holes for screws and bolts should be placed. When cut out using the provided template, all figures are compatible with one another and can be connected in any orientation, ensuring modularity and flexibility in assembly.

5.4 The Manual

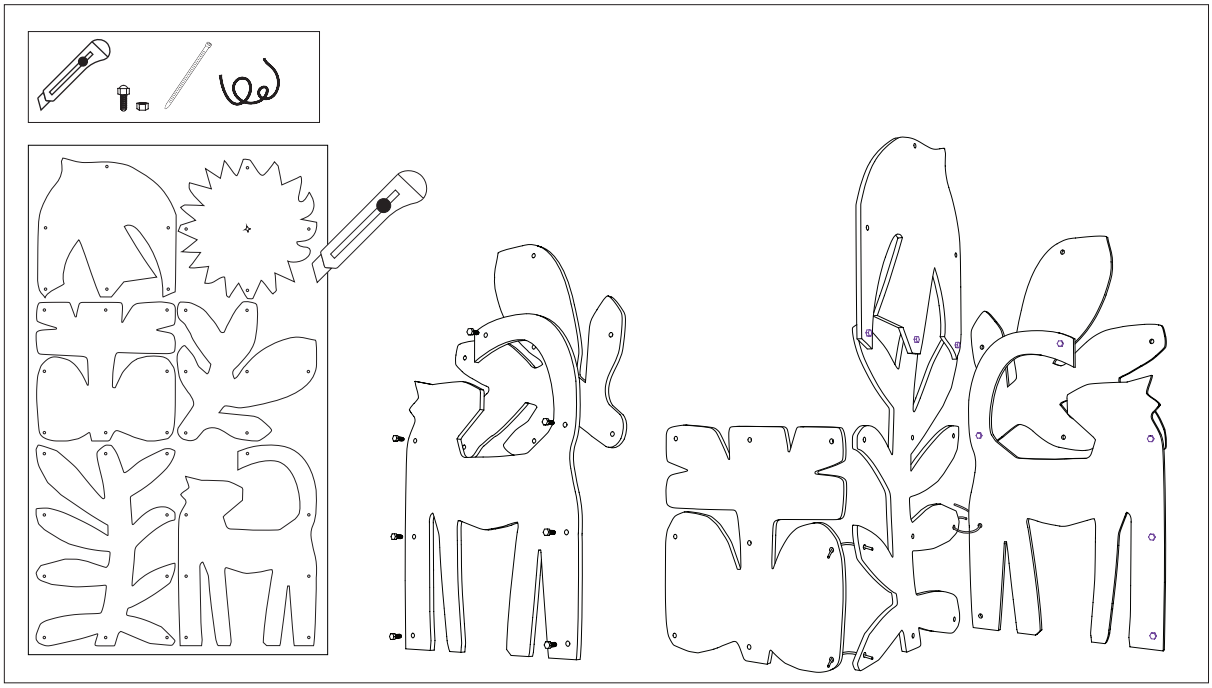


Figure 9: Manual (Kjellin Larsson 2025)

The toolbox contains a manual that, in a very simple manner and using only illustrations, explains the concept and how to cut and assemble the figures. It includes spatial examples that show different variations for creating walls and "rooms." The manual is printed on the inside of each cardboard sheet. Additional templates will be included as separate sheets in the box, allowing children to create their own motifs. This enables them to explore other ideas and concepts using the same principle. The process also opens up opportunities for collaboration between children and adults, encouraging shared creation and storytelling. This approach supports increased participation in both design and narrative construction, which can further strengthen children's agency and creative capacity.



Figure 10: Drawing (Kjellin Larsson 2025)

5.5 Spatialty

With the figures, spatiality can be created—both through formations that generate small enclosures and through various types of walls that create separations. These can provide privacy from the street, or they can be arranged as small labyrinths for children to play in and move between.

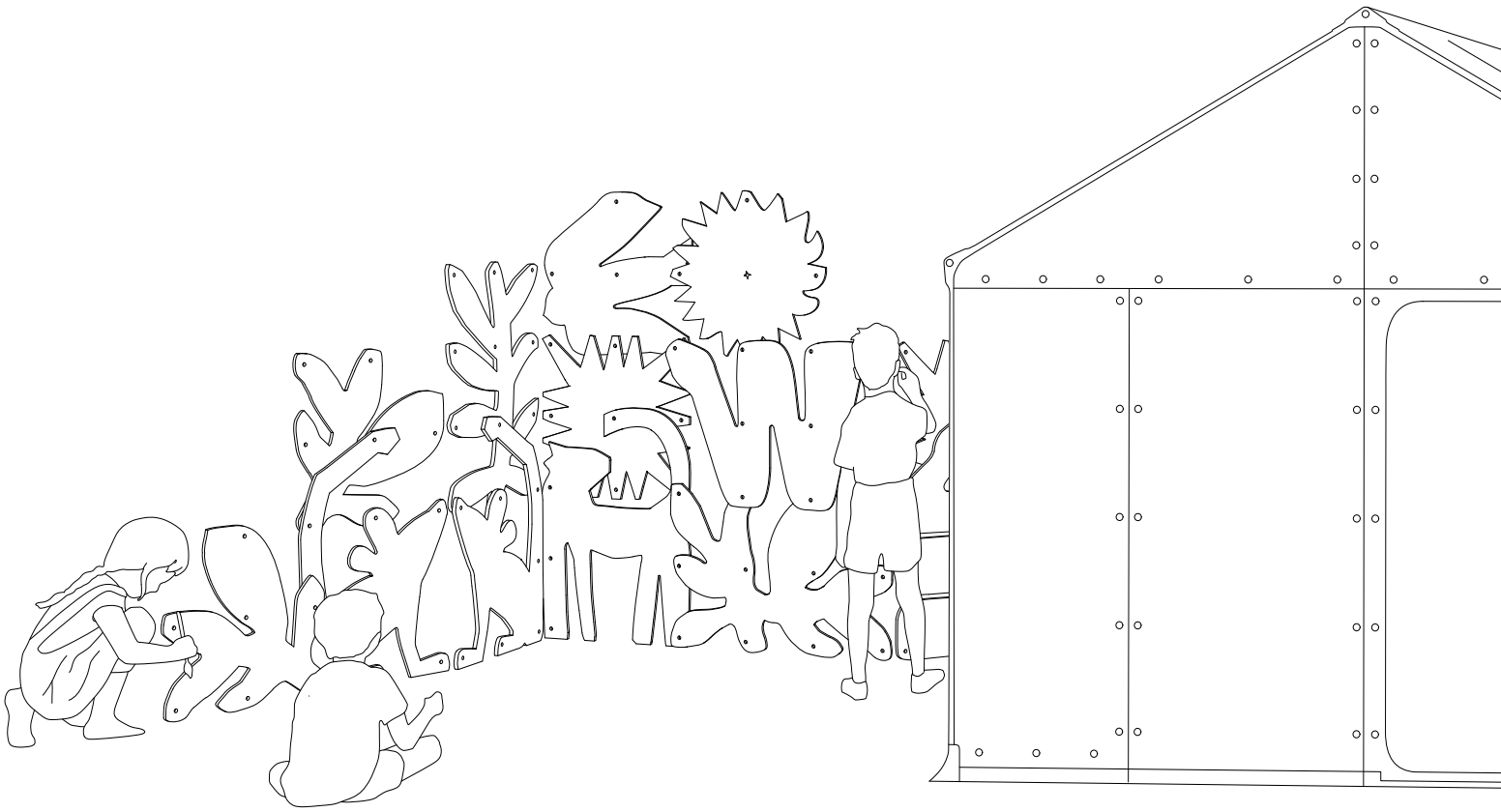


Figure 11: Drawing (Kjellin Larsson 2025)

5.6 Placement

When the shelters are set up according to specified dimensions, they create spaces between them that can function as courtyards. I have explored how these in-between spaces can be utilized, transforming them into areas for play beyond the immediate family home.

The intended placement of the play structures is based on the concept of place attachment discussed in Chapter III, p. 14. A hands-on engagement that allows children to embed personal and collective meanings into a place and establish a connection with their immediate living environment in order to develop a sense of belonging.

A study focusing on Palestinian refugee children found that children tend to spend time in places they perceive as safe and protective. It is also noted that there may be differences between where boys and girls tend to play, with girls preferring quieter, more private spaces and staying closer to home (Veronese et al. 2020). For these reasons, the availability of nearby, accessible spaces for play and creative activity is of great importance, particularly in displacement contexts, as it increases the likelihood that such activities can actually take place. It also encourages collaboration and connection by bringing children together through shared activities.

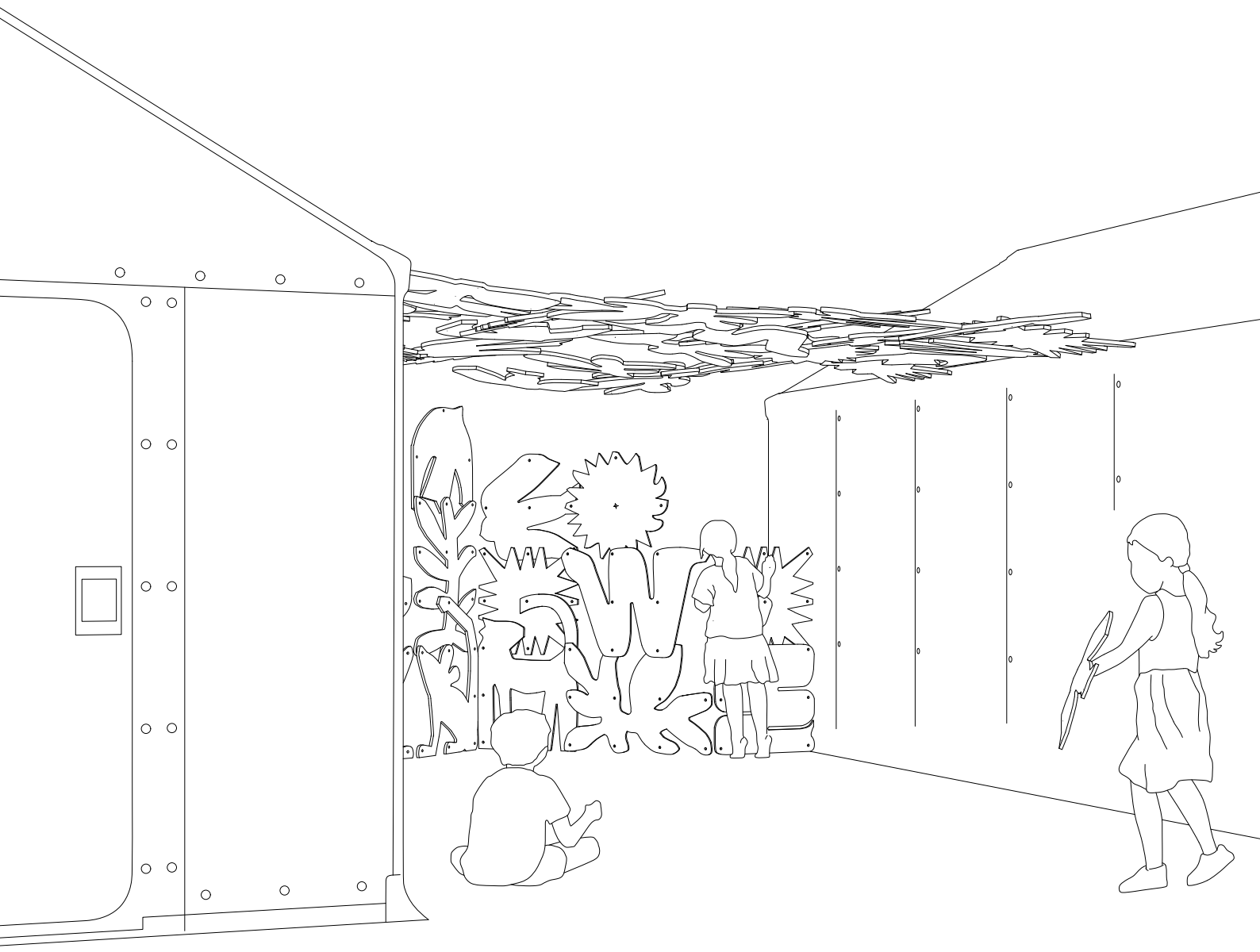


Figure 12: Drawing (Kjellin Larsson 2025)

One of the most important aspects of the project has been using simple, small-scale means to support vulnerable children's access to playful activities and to contribute to the creation of more child-friendly environments. I believe it is crucial to continuously explore and examine different systems for integrating child-focused activities and products into various contexts. With more frequent efforts and experimentation, the outcomes can become both more effective and, hopefully, more widely implemented.



Figure 13: *Assembling Play/Unfolding Space* (Kjellin Larsson 2025)



Figure 14: *Assembling Play/Unfolding Space* (Kjellin Larsson 2025)

Chapter VI/

discussion and conclusions

In the following section, I will discuss and reflect on the outcomes of the project and how they relate to its initial aims and key research questions. I will highlight the knowledge and insights gained, as well as the conclusions drawn from both the project development and the reserach. Additionally, I will reflect on my own professional growth throughout the process and consider the project's relevance. Finally, I will raise further reflections and questions as a continuation of this project, both for its potential realisation and for exploration in future work.

6.1 Summary and Discussion

This project explores how play can be facilitated in crisis situations, how temporary spatial interventions can create safe, child-friendly environments, and how opportunities for play and creativity can be integrated into existing emergency response systems to support play, playfulness, and social interaction for children affected by war or crisis. It also serves as a way to explore how my knowledge of design and spatial practice can be applied within critically engaged and socially conscious projects, beyond the realm of commercial practice.

My intention was to explore methods through which children can engage with spatiality through play, aiming to foster a sense of ownership and emotional connection to their environment—drawing inspiration from placemaking practices that support the development of place attachment.

The value of the project lies, among other things, in the knowledge I have gained by studying methods and concepts commonly used when designing for children. This includes insights gathered through meetings, conversations, and workshops related to play and participation, and how these approaches might be applied in the design of spaces for children. Attempting to apply this knowledge within the project has been both educational and challenging. In some areas, I have not been able to fully realise my goals—primarily due to limitations in time and

access to relevant networks. These limitations have particularly affected the possibility of collaborating with children and local organisations—relationships that require time and trust to develop.

However, I believe the project responds well to the intention and aim of exploring ways to support play in situations of war and crisis. The project offers an idea that holds strong potential for implementation and integration into existing emergency response systems. With that said, the idea and concept would likely benefit from further development or take new directions if children were involved more extensively, particularly through full-scale prototyping. Such participation would be advantageous in several ways—not only from a technical standpoint, by assessing how easily the design can be assembled and understood—but also in terms of design and form. Children's involvement could also generate further ideas and opportunities to expand the project, informed by their input and creativity.

During the process, I also gained valuable insights from research on the role of art and play in psychosocial care, and how creative activities, participation, and placemaking can promote resilience and place attachment. This knowledge will be useful in future projects related to interior architecture and environmental psychology—fields where these themes are highly relevant. Environmental psychology, which examines the interaction between individuals and their surroundings, is particularly applicable to many projects involving the design of environments for children. The relationship between spatial context and children's well-being and development has been central to this project and is strongly connected to broader design practices.

A combination of interdisciplinary knowledge—both practical and theoretical—acquired throughout the course of the project led me to the final result. This may represent a concept and method that could be useful within the field of humantitarian design and architecture—opening up possibilities for identifying new potentials within existing systems, and for collaboration with designers and children who together can bring new perspectives to current emergency response systems.

6.2 Final Reflections

The project is highly relevant today, as introducing opportunities for play to children affected by displacement is of critical importance in light of current global contexts of war and environmental crises. These conditions place children in particularly vulnerable situations, often in environments where educational resources and safe play spaces are limited or absent. A strength of the project is its dual focus on both social and environmental issues—repurposing materials to reduce the need for new resources and minimise environmental impact, while ultimately supporting children's opportunities for play and development, integrated into an existing system.

However, the project is subject to certain limitations in its current form. In order to effectively evaluate the impact of *Assembling Play/Unfolding Space*, the concept requires testing, implementation, and critical assessment within real-life contexts involving children.

Ultimately, what is most urgently needed is a decisive end to the conditions that expose children to violence, displacement, and instability. Addressing the root causes of armed conflict and oppression is essential. Sustainable peace, the protection of human rights, and the establishment of justice are fundamental prerequisites for creating safe and nurturing environments in which children can recover, develop, and realize their full potential.



Figure 15: *Assembling Play/Unfolding Space* (Kjellin Larsson 2025)



Figure 16: *Assembling Play/Unfolding Space* (Kjellin Larsson 2025)



Figure 17: *Assembling Play/Unfolding Space* (Kjellin Larsson 2025)

List of/
References

Andemicael, Awet. (2011). *Positive energy - A review of the role of artistic activities in refugee camps*. Policy Development and Evaluation Service United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees (PDES)

Architecture Sans Frontières International. (2022). *Challeging Practice - Essentials for the social production of the habitat.* Second edition

Ardelean, Ana. (2021). *Play in a refugee camp: disorder from chaos*. International Journal of Play, 10:4, p. 355-360, doi: 10.1080/21594937.2021.2005395

Dar, Anandini & Chopra, Divya. (2022). *Co-Designing Urban Play Spaces to Improve Migrant Children's Wellbeing*. IDS Policy Briefing 199, Brighton: Institute of Development Studies, doi: 10.19088/IDS.2022.044

Erwander, Eva, Teimouri, Mania & Wärff, Emilia. (2013). *Lekande läkande rum.* Göteborg: Kultur i Väst.

Esmailian, Shora. (2024). *Gaza. Att Spränga ett getto.* Falun: Verbal Förlag.

Feldman, Daniel. (2019). *Children's Play in the Shadow of War*. [Elektronisk] American Journal of Play, 11:3, p. 288-307.

Friedman, Yona. (2006). *Yona Friedman / Pro Dom*o. Acar and Junta de Andalucía.

Forensic Architecture. *An interactive cartographic platform: 'A Cartography of Genocide'*. https://forensic-architecture.org/investigation/a-cartography-of-genocide [2025.06.04]

Geertje Slingerland, Stephan Lukosch, and Frances Brazier. (2020). *Engaging Children to Co-create Outdoor Play Activities for Place-making*. In Proceedings of the 16th Participatory Design Conference 2020 - Participation(s) Otherwise - Vol 1 (PDC '20: Vol. 1), June 15–20, 2020, Manizales, Colombia. ACM, New York, USA, doi: 10.1145/3385010.3385017

Gifford, Sandra, Correa-Velez, Ignacio, & Sampson, Robyn. (2010). *Good Starts for refugee youth*. Curriculum and Leadership Journal, 8(24), 1

Hilal, Sandi & Petti, Alessandro. (2018). *Permanent Temporariness*. Art & Theory Publishing.

Holly Weir, Matluba Khan & Alexi Marmot. (2023). *Displaced children's experience of places and play: a scoping review*. Children's Geographies, 21:3, 502-517, doi: 10.1080/14733285.2022.2078656

Jacobs, Karrie. (2017). *Rethinking the Refugee Camp*. (https://www.architectmagazine.com/design/rethinking-the-refugee-camp) [2025.06.14]

Khalidi, Rashid. (2024). *'A new abyss': Gaza and the hundred years' war on Palestine.* The Guardian. Available at: https://www.theguardian.com/world/2024/apr/11/a-new-abyss-gaza-and-the-hundred-years-war-on-palestine [2025.01.14]

MacGregor, Marion. (2019). *Design for refugees: When does a shelter become a home?* https://www.infomigrants.net/fr/post/17921/design-for-refugees-when-does-a-shelter-become-a-home?) [2025.05.14]

Nylund, Viktor, Legrand, Jean Claude & Holtsberg, Peter. (1999). *The role of art in psychosocial care and protection for displaced children.* Forced Migration Review, Issue 6, pp. 16–19. UNICEF (https://www.fmreview.org/nylund-legrand-holtsberg/) [2024.11.14]

O'Keeffe, Paul. (2023). *Art as a Passport for Learning and Healing in Refugee Camps*, https://www.europenowjournal.org/2023/11/20/art-as-passport-for-learning-and-healing-in-refugee-camps/

PIBS, The Palestine Institute for Biodiversity and Sustainability. (https://www.palestinenature.org/) [2024.12.15]

PMNH, The Palestine Museum of Natural History. (https://www.palestinenature.org/) [2024.12.15]

Riash , Abdelhakim Abu. (2023). *Small moments of joy amid Israel-Gaza war for children at al-Shifa Hospital.* Al Jazeera. [2025.02.15]

Rigon, Andrea, Conti, Riccardo L & Dabaj, Joana. (2021). *Co-designing built interventions with children affected by displacement* (DeCID), UNICEF, UN-Habitat, CatalyticAction, University College London.

Rigon, Andrea, Dabaj, Joana & Conti, Riccardo. (2023). *Belonging and agency: The transformatory power of participatory design with children affected by displacement*, in Thomas, N.P., Percy-Smith, B. and Twum-Danso Imoh, A. (eds.) *Handbook of Children and Young People's Participation: Conversations for Transformational Change*. Abingdon: Routledge, pp. 265-274.

Rouveyrolles-Bazire, Chloe. (2024). *Gaza children 'extremely impacted' by war: UNICEF*, Al Monitor (https://www.al-monitor.com/originals/2024/10/gaza-children-extremely-impacted-war-unicef) [2025.01.10]

Russell, Catherine. (2023). *The Cost of War Will Be Counted in Children's Lives.* The Atlantic [2024.12.01] (https://www.theatlantic.com/ideas/archive/2023/10/unicef-cost-gaza-war-children/675780/)

Salamah, Alaa. (2024). *Palestinian children heal through art amid Israel's war on Gaza*, Socialist Worker, Issue 2908 (https://socialistworker.co.uk/in-depth/palestinian-children-heal-through-art-amid-israels-war-on-gaza/) [2025.02.15]

Salama, Ahmed. (2024). *Preserving Palestinian identity: Empowering children through art amid conflict and cultural loss.* New Arab. (https://www.newarab.com/features/empowering-palestinian-children-through-art-amid-conflict) [2025.02.15]

Shoshan, Malkit. (2023). *Spaces of Hope in Uncertain Times*, 51: Multihyphenate F/W 2023, Harvard Design Magazine. (https://www.harvarddesignmagazine.org/articles/spaces-of-hope-in-uncertain-times/) [2025.01.03]

Shoshan, Malkit & Bortolotti, Maurizio. (2014). *Village: One Land Two Systems & Platform Paradise*, FAST (https://seamlessterritory.org/village/) [2024.12.19]

UNICEF. (2024). *A year of tears, 12 mounth of war on children.*

United Nations. (1989). *Convention on the Rights of the Child.* Available at: https://www.ohchr.org/en/instruments-mechanisms/instruments/convention-rights-child [2024.11.04]

UNHCR. (2024). *Figures at a Glance.* United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees. Available at: https://www.unhcr.org/about-unhcr/overview/figures-glance [2025.06.07]

War Child. (2024). *War Child shares first study of psychological impact of war on vulnerable children in Gaza.* Available at: https://www.warchild.org.uk/news/war-child-shares-first-study-psychological-impact-war-vulnerable-children-gaza [2025.06.07]